



NEW RAILHEAD
The exterior (far left) and platforms of Sir MV railway terminal at Baiyappanahalli, Bengaluru



Photographs by SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

following of users, including techies travelling to the IT parks at Electronics City in the south and Whitefield in the east.

Software engineer Narendranath H.S. is one them. He recounts that he had even opted to move to Mysore a few years ago just to avoid the 31 km (one-way) commute to Electronics City from north Bengaluru. That was before he discovered that a daily commuter train passing through his locality covered that distance in about 40 minutes. "I was amazed by the connectivity system that existed," he says. Over time, company buses ferried employees to and from the connecting station, Heelalige. Action happening, in effect, only because of the initiative of users, Narendranath points out. "This had to be done by some authority. But because of the helplessness, this system developed on its own," he says. "The BSRP will definitely improve things, but it will take a few years to materialise. You need this skeletal service until you get the main service," he adds.

The BSRP and the Bengaluru Metro are currently the two major mobility infrastructure projects in Bengaluru. Both are meant to work in tandem—the suburban lines bring in passengers from the outskirts and the metrolines will serve the core parts of the city. However, the metroline has been stymied by delays. The 42-km Phase 1 metroline was completed in 2017 and work on a 72-km Phase 2 is in progress. The deadline for Phase 2, delayed because of land acquisition hurdles, is 2024. In 2021, the Union cabinet approved two new metrolines, called 2A and 2B, which will connect the southeast arc all along Bengaluru's IT corridor to the city's airport at Devanahalli in the north. The Bangalore Metro Rail Corporation Limited (BMRCL) expects to have a total network of 175 km operational by 2025.

ONLY A SMOOTH, SEAMLESS MASS RAPID TRANSIT SYSTEM CAN WEAN PEOPLE FROM PERSONAL VEHICLES

There has been much discussion on the need for a unified metropolitan transport authority in Bengaluru which could bring policy on all modes of transport under one roof. "Bengaluru has the bits and pieces, but it doesn't have the binding glue," says activist Srinivas Alavilli, who ran a campaign for the suburban rail a few years ago.

"Public transport, especially mass rapid transit systems, whether it is the metro or suburban rail, is what is going to save a city like Bengaluru from becoming a dead city," says Ashish Verma, convenor of the Sustainable Transportation Lab at the Indian Institute of Science. Only a seamless experience will make public transport attractive enough to wean motorists away from personal vehicles. For that to happen, various agencies cannot work in silos, he says. ■